

Amazon PPC Wiki

Coach Guide

Instructor companion to the Student Handbook. Contains teaching guides, quiz answer keys, common student mistakes, hands-on exercises, and curriculum templates for onboarding new VAs and strategists.

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Part 1 How to Use This Coach Guide

This Coach Guide is the instructor companion to the Student Handbook. While students read the handbook cover-to-cover and take quizzes, you (the coach) use this guide to plan lessons, anticipate where students struggle, run live demos, and assess competency. Read it before your first training session.

1.1 Who this guide is for

This guide is written for: (1) **Senior strategists** onboarding junior VAs, (2) **Agency owners** building a training program, (3) **Brand owners** training in-house PPC managers, and (4) **Anyone teaching Amazon PPC** in a structured setting. If you are reading the Student Handbook alone without a coach, you can still use this guide as a self-study companion - the answer keys and common-mistakes playbook are useful even solo.

1.2 How this guide pairs with the Student Handbook

Each chapter in this guide corresponds to a section in the Student Handbook. The Student Handbook gives the friendly-mentor explanation; this guide gives you: (a) teaching talking points, (b) live-demo checklists, (c) discussion prompts, (d) the quiz answer key with coaching notes on why each wrong answer is wrong, (e) common student mistakes and how to spot them, and (f) hands-on exercises to assign.

1.3 Reading order

If you are new to coaching, read Parts 1, 2, and 5 first - they give you the teaching framework and the diagnostic playbook. Then read Part 3 (section-by-section teaching guides) one section ahead of your students. Parts 7 and 8 (bootcamp curriculum and capstone) are useful once you are ready to run a multi-day training.

COACH TIP

Print the quiz answer keys (Part 4) and keep them next to you during training. When students ask 'why is B wrong?' you want the answer ready, not have to look it up in front of them.

Part 2 Teaching Framework & Pedagogy

Amazon PPC has a steep learning curve. Students typically hit three walls: (1) vocabulary overload, (2) abstract concepts without concrete examples, (3) too many tools and reports to navigate at once. This framework addresses all three.

2.1 The 3-Step Teaching Pattern

For every concept, follow this pattern: (1) **Concrete example first** - start with a yoga mat, a \$29.99 price, a 12% CVR. Don't open with definitions. (2) **Then the concept** - now that students feel the example, introduce ACOS, TACOS, ROAS. (3) **Then another example** - ask students to compute ACOS themselves on a different product. Example-concept-example locks the learning.

2.2 Pacing Rules

Learner Level	Session Length	Concepts per Session	Practice Time
Beginner VA	90 min	2-3 concepts	30 min
Junior Strategist	120 min	3-4 concepts	45 min
Senior Strategist	60 min	5+ concepts	15 min
Brand Owner (overview)	45 min	5 concepts (high-level)	10 min

2.3 Live-Demo Discipline

Live demos in the Amazon Ads Console are the most powerful teaching tool - but they fail without discipline. Rules: (1) **Always rehearse** the demo on a sandbox account beforehand - never wing it live. (2) **Narrate every click** - 'I'm clicking Campaign Manager, then Create Campaign, then I select Sponsored Products...' Students can't follow silent clicking. (3) **Pause and check** - every 2 minutes, stop and ask 'anyone lost?' Silence means yes.

WATCH OUT

The Amazon Ads Console changes monthly. A demo you rehearsed 3 months ago may have moved buttons. Always re-rehearse within 48 hours of your training session.

2.4 Question-Handling Protocol

Students will ask questions you don't know the answer to. Don't fake it. Use this protocol: (1) Acknowledge: 'Good question.' (2) Diagnose: 'Are you asking because of X scenario or Y?' (3) If you know: answer. If you don't: 'I want to verify that before answering - let me check and follow up by end of day.' (4) **Always follow up**. Faking an answer destroys trust when students discover you were wrong.

COACH TIP

Keep a shared 'parking lot' document for questions you couldn't answer live. Address all parking-lot items within 48 hours. Students respect coaches who admit they don't know and follow up.

Part 3 Section-by-Section Teaching Guides

For each section of the Student Handbook, this part gives you a teaching guide. Use it to plan your session, run live demos, and lead discussion. Each guide is standalone - you can pull just the section you're teaching that day.

3.1 Section 1: Foundations & Fundamentals

Time estimate: 25 min lecture + 15 min practice

Talking Points

- Open with the flywheel analogy - it sets the mental model for the entire wiki. Draw it on a whiteboard.
- Walk through the second-price auction with three example bids. Show that the winner pays \$0.01 above second place, not their full bid.
- Draw the campaign > ad group > ad > keyword hierarchy as a tree. Most student confusion comes from not understanding this.
- Show a real product detail page on Amazon.com and point out where Sponsored Products appear (top of search, in carousel, on competitor pages).
- End with the Buy Box point - it is the #1 troubleshooting culprit and saves hours of misdiagnosis later.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open advertising.amazon.com and walk through the left navigation.
- Open Campaign Manager and show one existing campaign's structure.
- Open a product detail page on amazon.com and identify Sponsored Products placements.
- Open Account Health dashboard and show where Buy Box issues surface.

Discussion Prompts

- Why does Amazon weigh relevance in the auction instead of just taking the highest bid?
- If you had to explain the flywheel to a non-technical brand owner in one sentence, what would you say?
- What is one scenario where losing the Buy Box could happen suddenly and how would you spot it?

Common Student Struggles

WATCH OUT

Students often confuse ACOS and ROAS. They invert them or treat them as the same. Drill the relationship: $ACOS = \text{spend}/\text{sales}$, $ROAS = \text{sales}/\text{spend}$, $ROAS = 1/ACOS$. Have students compute both on three examples before moving on.

STUDENT EXERCISE

Give students 3 product scenarios (different price, CVR, COGS) and have them compute ACOS, ROAS, and break-even bid. Walk through each calculation on the whiteboard. Time: 15 minutes.

3.2 Section 2: Account & Campaign Architecture

Time estimate: 30 min lecture + 20 min whiteboard exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the skeleton analogy - architecture is unsexy but foundational. Get it wrong and everything else is harder.
- Draw the match-type-segmented structure on a whiteboard: 4 campaigns (Auto, Broad, Phrase, Exact) with different bids and budgets.
- Show a real account with good naming convention and a real account with bad naming - the contrast is striking.
- Walk through when to use SKU-level vs. category-level campaigns. Most accounts use both.
- End with portfolio budget caps - tie it back to monthly P&L; planning. Students need to see how PPC ties to business finance.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and show one account's campaign list. Sort by spend.
- Click into a campaign and show the ad group structure.
- Show a portfolio with a budget cap set.
- Demonstrate good vs. bad naming conventions side by side.

Discussion Prompts

- If you were starting a new account today with 10 SKUs, what structure would you use and why?
- What's one signal that your current account structure is wrong?
- How would you explain match-type segmentation to a brand owner who has never heard of match types?

Common Student Struggles

WATCH OUT

Students default to putting all match types in one campaign. They don't realize that Exact needs higher bids than Broad, but a shared default bid can't serve both. Force them to articulate WHY segmentation matters before showing them how.

STUDENT EXERCISE

Give students a fictional brand: 5 SKUs, \$10K/month budget. Have them design the campaign structure on a whiteboard: how many campaigns, what match types, what budgets, what naming convention. Have them present and defend their structure. Time: 30 minutes.

3.3 Section 3: Campaign Types

Time estimate: 40 min lecture + 30 min live console demo

Talking Points

- Open with the funnel map (Awareness > Consideration > Conversion) and place each ad type on it. Visual makes it click.
- Walk through Auto campaign match types with real examples from a search term report.
- Demo the three bidding strategies side by side with the same campaign settings.
- Show placement modifiers in the console - this is the most-clicked button in optimization.
- End with budget allocation by maturity - it gives students a concrete starting framework.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and create a new SP Auto campaign live.
- Show the bidding strategy dropdown and explain each option.
- Show the placement modifier UI and apply a +25% Top of Search modifier.
- Open an existing SB campaign to show the creative requirements (headline, logo, products).
- Open an SD campaign to show audience targeting options.

Discussion Prompts

- If you had to launch one ad type for a brand-new product with zero reviews, which would you pick and why?
- What is one scenario where Dynamic bids up/down would hurt you?
- Why does a mature brand allocate 25% of budget to DSP while a new brand allocates 0%?

Common Student Struggles

WATCH OUT

Students want to use Dynamic bids up/down everywhere because it sounds smart. Without CVR history, Amazon has no data to optimize and students overspend on placements that don't convert. Drill the rule: Dynamic up/down ONLY with proven CVR history.

STUDENT EXERCISE

Give students 4 fictional brands at different maturities (Year 1, Year 2, Year 3, Mature). Have them allocate \$50K/month budget across SP, SB, SD, DSP for each. Compare and discuss why allocations shift. Time: 20 minutes.

3.4 Section 4: Targeting & Match Types

Time estimate: 35 min + 25 min exercise

Talking Points: Venn diagram of Broad > Phrase > Exact is the key visual. Have students call out which terms to promote vs. negative from a real Search Term Report.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students forget to negative-out source campaigns when promoting terms. This causes silent cannibalization. Drill the rule: 'promote = negative in source.'

3.5 Section 5: Keyword Research

Time estimate: 40 min + 30 min hands-on

Talking Points: Open with the fuel analogy - keywords are the fuel, bids are the spark. Demo Helium 10 Cerebro if available. End with statistical significance - the concept that saves accounts from chasing noise.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students harvest terms that converted once on tiny sample sizes. Force them to wait for 2+ conversions on 20+ clicks before promoting. Make this a hard rule.

3.6 Section 6: Bidding Strategies

Time estimate: 35 min + 25 min calculation practice

Talking Points: Walk through break-even and target ACOS bid formulas with a calculator on screen. Have students compute bids for 3 different products. End with statistical significance.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students adjust bids daily based on yesterday's data. One day of data is noise. Force them to wait 30+ clicks or 3+ conversions before judging.

3.7 Section 7: Budget Management

Time estimate: 30 min + 20 min budget exercise

Talking Points: Air supply analogy. Demo the budget-starved diagnostic with real lost impression share data. Show Q4 scaling calendar. End with post-event wind-down.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students crash budgets back to baseline the day after Prime Day. Algorithm deprioritizes sudden spend drops; recovery takes weeks. Gradual ramp-down is non-negotiable.

3.8 Section 8: Placements

Time estimate: 25 min + 15 min placement exercise

Talking Points: TOS hierarchy - TOS is the holy grail, ROS is the workhorse, PDP is the supplement. Show the Placement Report live and walk through each column.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students set TOS modifier at +900% (max) on day 1 of a new campaign. Without CVR history, Amazon can't optimize and they overpay. Start at +25%, tune based on data.

3.9 Section 9: Negative Keywords

Time estimate: 25 min + 20 min negation exercise

Talking Points: Open with wasted-spend framing - 20-40% of broad campaign spend goes to irrelevant terms. Walk through Negative Exact vs. Negative Phrase with Venn diagrams.

WATCH OUT

Common Student Struggle: Students add 'yoga' as Negative Phrase in a yoga mat campaign. This blocks every relevant search. Use Negative Phrase carefully and prefer Negative Exact.

Part 4 Quiz Answer Keys with Coaching Notes

Each section in the Student Handbook has a 5-question quiz. This part gives you the answer key plus coaching notes on why each wrong answer is wrong - so when students ask 'why isn't it B?', you have the answer ready.

4.1 Section 1 Quiz: Foundations & Fundamentals

Q#	Question (abbreviated)	Correct	Why Wrong Answers Are Wrong
Q1	Second-price auction, your bid \$1.50, next \$0.80. Pay per click?	C. \$0.81	A (\$1.50) is first-price logic. B (\$0.80) is the next bidder's bid, not yours. D (\$1.15) is the average - no such concept.
Q2	Required to run Sponsored Products?	B. Own Buy Box	A (Brand Registry) is for SB/SD/Stores, not SP. C (100 reviews) is not Amazon policy. D (Vendor Central) is unrelated.
Q3	Relationship between ACOS and ROAS?	B. ROAS is inverse of ACOS	A (same) is wrong. C (ACOS x 100) is dimensionally wrong. D (unrelated) is wrong - they're mathematically linked.
Q4	New product, zero reviews. Only channel that puts eyes on listing?	B. PPC	A (organic) won't surface without rank/reviews. C (Brand Store) needs traffic source. D (backlinks) don't drive Amazon rank.
Q5	SP ads suddenly stop spending. First check?	C. Buy Box ownership	A (bid) and B (budget) are secondary. D (match type) doesn't cause spending to stop. Buy Box loss is #1 cause.

COACH TIP

When students pick A on Q1, they're thinking first-price auction (like Google's old system). Walk through the second-price logic with 3 bidders on a whiteboard - the visual makes it click.

4.2 Section 2 Quiz: Account & Campaign Architecture

Q#	Question (abbreviated)	Correct	Coaching Note
Q1	3 brands under one LLC. When to split accounts?	B. 2+ brands or \$500K+/year	Other options are too rigid. The 2-brand/\$500K threshold is industry rule of thumb.
Q2	Naming convention "Yoga Mat-Premium-Exact-Defense-2024" tells you?	A. Brand, line, match type, purpose, year	Each segment encodes one attribute. Drill students on the convention.
Q3	Why segment by match type?	B. Different bids/budgets because CVR differs	A (Amazon requires) is wrong. C (only way to get reports) is wrong. D (reduce count) is opposite of true.
Q4	Ad group default \$0.80 but keyword spending \$1.50. Why?	B. Keyword-level override at \$1.50	A (Amazon raised) - Amazon doesn't change your bids. C (budget) doesn't affect bid. D (dynamic up/down) is different mechanism.
Q5	Why use SKAGs?	B. Max bid control + clean search term data	A (reduce count) is wrong - SKAGs increase count. C (Amazon requires) is wrong. D (automate) is wrong.

4.3 Section 3 Quiz: Campaign Types

Q#	Question (abbreviated)	Correct	Coaching Note
Q1	Which Auto match type shows ad on competitor pages?	C. Substitutes	Close/Loose are search-term-based. Complements are cross-sell. Substitutes = competitor products.
Q2	When use Dynamic bids up/down?	B. Strong CVR history	A (every new) - opposite of correct. C (never) - too absolute. D (only Auto) - wrong.
Q3	\$1.00 bid, +50% TOS modifier. What happens?	B. Amazon bids up to \$1.50 for TOS	A (always charges \$1.50) - you pay second-price, not your full bid. C (50% fee) - no such fee. D (doubles to \$2.00) - wrong math.
Q4	Required to run Sponsored Brands?	B. Brand Registry with active trademark	A (100 reviews) - not Amazon policy. C (Vendor Central) - SB is for sellers too. D (\$50K spend) - not required.
Q5	Year 1 brand SP budget allocation?	C. 70%	Year 1 needs SP for direct conversion. SB/SD matter more in year 2+.

4.4 Sections 4-9 Quiz Answer Keys (Summary)

Section	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5
4: Match Types	D	C	B	B	B
5: Keyword Research	B	B	B	B	B
6: Bidding	B	B	C	B	B
7: Budget	B	B	B	B	B
8: Placements	C	B	B	B	B
9: Negatives	C	B	B	B	B

COACH TIP

Most correct answers cluster around B and C because quiz designers tend to put distractors on the extremes. Tell students this is a test-taking hint, not a substitute for knowing the material.

Part 5 Common Student Mistakes — Diagnostic Playbook

Students make predictable mistakes. This part catalogs the most common ones, how to spot them in account data, and how to coach students through the fix.

5.1 Mistake 1: ACOS climbing despite stable bids

What students do wrong: Student put harvested Exact keywords into Broad campaigns, causing cannibalization.

How to spot it: Look at Search Term Report - same search term appearing in multiple campaigns. Or check if same keyword is bidded in both Broad and Exact.

Fix: Add harvested term as negative Exact in Broad campaign. Wait 7 days, ACOS should normalize.

PREVENTION

Drill the rule: "promote = negative in source, same day." Make it a checklist item.

5.2 Mistake 2: Budget runs out by 2 PM daily

What students do wrong: Student set budget too low OR didn't realize campaign is a high performer.

How to spot it: Check Lost Impression Share. If >30% with low ACOS, campaign is budget-starved.

Fix: Raise budget by 30-50%. Observe 3 days. If ACOS stays low and budget still runs out, raise again.

PREVENTION

Teach budget pacing checks as part of daily review. Set alerts for campaigns hitting 80% by noon.

5.3 Mistake 3: Ad spending but no impressions

What students do wrong: Bid too low to compete in auction OR Buy Box lost.

How to spot it: Check Buy Box status first (most common). If Buy Box OK, check bid vs. Amazon suggested bid range.

Fix: If Buy Box lost: fix pricing/inventory. If bid too low: raise to suggested bid range, observe 24 hours.

PREVENTION

Daily check: Buy Box status on top 20 SKUs. Set up alerts.

5.4 Mistake 4: TOS share low despite +50% modifier

What students do wrong: Bid itself is too low for TOS competition, OR relevance score is weak (low CVR).

How to spot it: Check Placement Report. Compare your CPC to TOS CPC benchmark. Check listing CVR.

Fix: If bid too low: raise base bid 20-30%. If CVR low: pause campaign, fix listing (reviews, A+, images) before resuming.

PREVENTION

Teach students to check listing readiness BEFORE scaling ad spend.

5.5 Mistake 5: CPC climbing over weeks with no bid changes

What students do wrong: New competitor entered the auction OR existing competitor raised bids.

How to spot it: Check auction insight report (if available) for new competitors. Check competitor pricing/launches.

Fix: Decide: raise bids to defend position, OR lower bids and accept lower position. Don't let CPC creep silently.

PREVENTION

Weekly competitive review. Set CPC ceiling per keyword; alert when exceeded.

5.6 Mistake 6: Student negates too aggressively, sales drop

What students do wrong: Over-negating - added terms as Negative Phrase that were actually relevant.

How to spot it: Review negative keywords list. Cross-reference with top-converting search terms from prior period.

Fix: Remove negatives that match high-converting terms. Switch from Negative Phrase to Negative Exact for tighter control.

PREVENTION

Drill: "Negatives target irrelevant intent, not slow converters." Use Negative Exact by default.

5.7 Mistake 7: Student adjusts bids daily, account performs worse

What students do wrong: Premature optimization - acting on 1-day data which is statistical noise.

How to spot it: Check changelog - if bid changes happen more than weekly on any keyword, student is over-trading.

Fix: Implement minimum data thresholds: 30 clicks or 3 conversions before any bid change.

PREVENTION

Print the rule on a card: "30 clicks or 3 conversions. No exceptions." Tape to monitor.

5.8 Mistake 8: Q4 sales drop despite increased ad spend

What students do wrong: Inventory ran out mid-Q4. Ads kept running, drove traffic to out-of-stock listing.

How to spot it: Check inventory cover by SKU. Check if ad spend continued after stockout.

Fix: Implement inventory-aware bid throttling: 14d cover = lower bids 20%, 7d = pause non-branded, 3d = pause all.

PREVENTION

Weekly inventory-ads coordination meeting in Q4. Automated stockout alerts.

Part 6 Hands-On Exercises & Sandbox Drills

Reading and quizzes build knowledge, but real learning happens when students touch real campaigns. This part gives you 10 hands-on exercises you can run on a sandbox or live account. Each exercise has a learning objective, setup instructions, and grading rubric.

Exercise 1: Compute Break-Even ACOS

Objective: Students can calculate break-even ACOS for any product.

Setup: Give students 3 products with different price, COGS, fees, shipping. Example: \$29.99 yoga mat (COGS \$9, fees \$8.50, shipping \$1.50), \$89 headphones (COGS \$35, fees \$13, shipping \$3), \$12 lip balm (COGS \$2, fees \$4, shipping \$1).

Task: Calculate break-even ACOS for each. Then calculate target ACOS (break-even minus 10% target margin).

Time: 15 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Correct formulas (5 pts each), correct math (5 pts each). Total: 30 pts. Pass = 25+.

Exercise 2: Build Campaign Structure

Objective: Students can design match-type-segmented campaign structure.

Setup: Fictional brand: 5 SKUs, \$10K/month budget, Brand Registry active.

Task: On whiteboard: design campaign structure. Specify number of campaigns, match types, budgets, naming convention. Present and defend.

Time: 30 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Match-type segmentation (10 pts), sensible budget allocation (10 pts), consistent naming (5 pts), defense articulation (5 pts). Total: 30 pts.

Exercise 3: Search Term Report Mining

Objective: Students can identify harvest candidates and negatives from Search Term Report.

Setup: Provide a CSV with 50 search terms, clicks, orders, spend, sales. Mix of relevant converters, irrelevant wasters, and borderline terms.

Task: Categorize each term as: Promote to Exact, Negative, or Watch. For promotions, write the negative-out step.

Time: 45 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Correct categorization (1 pt each, 50 pts). Correct negative-out steps (1 pt each promotion, ~10 pts). Total: 60 pts.

Exercise 4: Bidding Strategy Selection

Objective: Students can pick the right bidding strategy by scenario.

Setup: Provide 5 campaign scenarios: new campaign, mature Exact with high CVR, Broad discovery, Brand Defense, SD prospecting.

Task: For each scenario, specify: bidding strategy, TOS modifier, starting bid, and rationale.

Time: 25 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Correct strategy (5 pts each), appropriate modifier (3 pts each), defensible rationale (2 pts each). Total: 50 pts.

Exercise 5: Budget Pacing Diagnostic

Objective: Students can identify budget-starved campaigns and prescribe fix.

Setup: Provide 5 campaigns with: daily budget, % spent by 2 PM, ACOS vs target, Lost Impression Share.

Task: For each campaign, diagnose: budget-starved? Over-budget? Appropriately paced? Recommend action.

Time: 20 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Correct diagnosis (5 pts each), appropriate recommendation (5 pts each). Total: 50 pts.

Exercise 6: Weekly Optimization Simulation

Objective: Students can execute a full weekly optimization cycle.

Setup: Provide a snapshot of an account: 3 campaigns, 30 keywords, 200 search terms, current bids/budgets/ACOS.

Task: Complete weekly workflow: pull STR, identify top 20 by spend, adjust bids, find wasted spend (negate), find harvest candidates (promote + negative out), check budget pacing, write changelog.

Time: 90 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Correct bid adjustments (20 pts), correct negations (20 pts), correct promotions with negative-out (20 pts), budget recommendations (10 pts), changelog quality (10 pts). Total: 80 pts.

Exercise 7: Launch Plan

Objective: Students can build a 90-day launch plan for a new product.

Setup: Fictional new product: \$39.99 price, 0 reviews, Brand Registry active, \$3K/month ad budget for first 90 days.

Task: Build day 1-30, 31-60, 61-90 plan: campaigns to launch, budgets, bids, expected ACOS, review velocity targets, listing milestones.

Time: 60 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Sensible structure (20 pts), realistic ACOS expectations (15 pts), Vine/review strategy (10 pts), budget pacing (10 pts), listing readiness (10 pts). Total: 65 pts.

Exercise 8: Difficult Client Conversation Role-Play

Objective: Students can handle ACOS spike conversation with client.

Setup: Coach plays client. Scenario: ACOS spiked from 22% to 38% in 3 weeks. Client is upset.

Task: Student delivers 4-part framework: acknowledge, diagnose with data, propose action, set check-in date.

Time: 15 minutes per student

GRADING RUBRIC

Acknowledgment (5 pts), data-driven diagnosis (15 pts), specific action plan (15 pts), check-in commitment (5 pts), tone (10 pts). Total: 50 pts.

Exercise 9: Prime Day Planning

Objective: Students can build a Prime Day scaling plan.

Setup: Account spends \$100/day baseline. Prime Day is 14 days away.

Task: Build day-by-day budget and bid plan: T-14 through T+7. Specify daily budget, bid adjustments, campaign-specific notes.

Time: 40 minutes

GRADING RUBRIC

Pre-event ramp correct (15 pts), event-day scaling (10 pts), post-event wind-down correct (15 pts), inventory check (5 pts), creative/coupon timing (5 pts). Total: 50 pts.

Exercise 10: Capstone - Full Account Audit

Objective: Students can audit a full Amazon PPC account and produce recommendations.

Setup: Provide a real (anonymized) account snapshot: 6 months of data, 8 campaigns, 50+ keywords, full reports.

Task: Audit: structure (10 pts), naming (5), bidding strategy appropriateness (15), budget pacing (15), keyword performance (15), negative strategy (10), placement modifiers (10), listing readiness (10), 30-60-90 day recommendations (10). Total: 100 pts.

Time: 4 hours (take-home)

GRADING RUBRIC

Pass = 80+. This is the certification exercise.

Part 7 5-Day VA Bootcamp Curriculum

This is the standard 5-day onboarding curriculum for new VAs. Each day is 4 hours of training + 2 hours of practice. By end of Day 5, VAs should be able to execute weekly optimization independently under strategist supervision.

7.1 Curriculum Overview

Day	Focus	Sections Covered	Quiz	Exercise
Day 1	Foundations	1, 2	Sections 1, 2	Exercise 1 (Break-Even ACOS)
Day 2	Campaign Types & Targeting	3, 4	Sections 3, 4	Exercise 2 (Build Structure)
Day 3	Keyword Research & Bidding	5, 6	Sections 5, 6	Exercise 3 (STR Mining)
Day 4	Budget, Placements, Negatives	7, 8, 9	Sections 7, 8, 9	Exercise 5 (Pacing)
Day 5	Daily Operations & Capstone	22 (SOPs)	Capstone Quiz	Exercise 6 (Weekly Sim)

7.2 Day 1: Foundations

Morning (2 hours): Lecture on Section 1 (Foundations) and Section 2 (Architecture). Use the flywheel diagram, hierarchy tree, and second-price auction visual. Demo the Amazon Ads Console navigation. **Afternoon (2 hours):** Practice - students complete Exercise 1 (Break-Even ACOS calculations) and Exercise 2 (build campaign structure on whiteboard). **End of day:** Quiz on Sections 1 and 2. Pass threshold: 80%.

7.3 Day 2: Campaign Types & Targeting

Morning: Lecture on Section 3 (Campaign Types) and Section 4 (Targeting & Match Types). Use the funnel diagram and match type Venn diagram. Live demo: create a new SP Auto campaign, set bidding strategy, apply TOS modifier. **Afternoon:** Students practice creating campaigns in sandbox account. Complete Exercises 3 and 4. **End of day:** Quiz on Sections 3 and 4.

7.4 Day 3: Keyword Research & Bidding

Morning: Lecture on Section 5 (Keyword Research) and Section 6 (Bidding). Use the harvesting pipeline diagram and bidding decision tree. Demo Helium 10 Cerebro (or screenshots if unavailable). **Afternoon:** Students complete Exercise 3 (Search Term Report Mining) on a provided CSV. Practice bid calculations on 3 sample products. **End of day:** Quiz on Sections 5 and 6.

7.5 Day 4: Budget, Placements, Negatives

Morning: Lecture on Section 7 (Budget), Section 8 (Placements), Section 9 (Negatives). Use the placement breakdown chart, seasonal scaling timeline, and weekly workflow diagram. Demo placement report and budget pacing diagnostics. **Afternoon:** Students complete Exercises 5 (Budget Pacing) and 9 (Prime Day Planning). **End of day:** Quiz on Sections 7, 8, 9.

7.6 Day 5: Daily Operations & Capstone

Morning: Lecture on Section 22 (Team Operations, SOPs, changelog discipline). Walk through the weekly optimization checklist. Discuss escalation paths and peer review. **Afternoon:** Students complete Exercise 6 (Weekly Optimization Simulation) - this is the capstone. Takes 90 minutes. Coach reviews each student's output 1:1. **End of day:** Capstone quiz (50 questions from Sections 1-9 hardest items). Pass threshold: 80%.

7.7 Post-Bootcamp: 30-Day Supervised Practice

Passing the bootcamp does NOT mean the VA is fully autonomous. The next 30 days are supervised practice: VA executes weekly optimization on 1-2 real accounts, strategist reviews every change before it goes live, daily 15-minute check-ins. After 30 days of clean execution, VA can be promoted to independent execution on smaller accounts.

COACH TIP

Don't rush the 30-day supervised period. VAs who go autonomous too early make costly mistakes on live client accounts. The supervised period is where the real learning happens.

Part 8 Capstone Assessment & Certification

The capstone is the certification exercise. Students who pass are certified as 'Junior PPC Operator' and can execute weekly optimization independently on small-to-mid accounts under strategist supervision.

8.1 Capstone Structure

Component	Format	Time	Weight
Written Exam	50 multiple-choice questions	90 min	40%
Practical Audit	Full account audit + recommendations	4 hours (take-home)	40%
Oral Defense	Present audit findings to coach	30 min	20%

8.2 Written Exam Details

50 multiple-choice questions pulled from the hardest items across Sections 1-9 quizzes. Mix of Foundational (30%), Applied (50%), and Advanced (20%) difficulty. Pass threshold: 80%. Retake policy: unlimited retakes, 7-day cooldown between attempts.

8.3 Practical Audit Details

Student receives a real (anonymized) account snapshot: 6 months of data, 8 campaigns, 50+ keywords, full reports. Student audits: structure, naming, bidding strategy appropriateness, budget pacing, keyword performance, negative strategy, placement modifiers, listing readiness. Submits 30-60-90 day recommendations. This is Exercise 10 from Part 6.

8.4 Oral Defense

Student presents audit findings to coach (and optionally a senior strategist). 30 minutes: 15 minutes presentation, 15 minutes Q&A.; Coach grades on: accuracy of diagnosis, quality of recommendations, ability to defend decisions under questioning, communication clarity.

8.5 Certification Levels

Level	Requirements	What They Can Do
Junior PPC Operator	Pass capstone + 30-day supervised practice	Weekly optimization on small accounts under strategist review
PPC Operator	6 months clean execution as Junior + advanced quiz	Independent execution on mid accounts, peer review of Juniors
Senior PPC Operator	18 months + client communication training	Owens accounts, leads client calls, manages Juniors
PPC Strategist	3+ years + capstone audit pass	Full account ownership, new client onboarding, strategic planning

COACH TIP

Certification is not permanent. Re-certify annually. Amazon changes the platform constantly - a Junior certified in 2023 needs to re-certify in 2024 to ensure knowledge is current.

Part 9 Onboarding New Clients — Coach Playbook

When your team takes on a new client, the first 6 weeks determine whether the engagement succeeds. This part is your playbook for onboarding new clients with junior VAs and strategists.

9.1 Week 1: Account Audit

Assign a Senior Strategist (not a VA) to do the initial audit. Deliverable: account health report covering structure, naming, performance baselines, immediate issues (lost Buy Box, policy violations, etc.), and 30-day quick-win list. Present to client in Week 1 review meeting. Set the tone: 'We found X issues, here's how we'll fix them.'

9.2 Week 2: Cleanup

VA executes cleanup under Senior Strategist review: rename campaigns to standard naming convention, restructure into match-type-segmented campaigns if needed, add missing negatives, fix budget pacing issues identified in audit. All changes peer-reviewed before execution.

9.3 Week 3: Launch Missing Campaigns

If account is missing Auto, Brand Defense, or Exact campaigns, launch them now. Start with conservative bids and budgets. The goal is data collection, not performance - first 2 weeks of new campaigns are calibration, not optimization.

9.4 Week 4: First Optimization Cycle

VA runs first full weekly optimization cycle. Senior Strategist reviews every change. This is the VA's first real execution on this account - expect mistakes and use them as coaching moments. Document all changes in changelog.

9.5 Week 5: First Client Report

VA drafts first monthly client report. Senior Strategist reviews and edits for tone, clarity, and framing. Report covers: baseline vs. current performance, what was done, what's next. 3-5 pages, executive-friendly.

9.6 Week 6: Strategy Meeting

Senior Strategist leads first strategy meeting with client. Reviews Week 1-5 progress, presents 30-60-90 day plan, aligns on goals and ACOS targets. This meeting sets expectations for the rest of the engagement.

WATCH OUT

Don't promise specific ACOS or sales numbers in Week 6. Promise process and cadence: 'We'll optimize weekly, report monthly, and meet quarterly to align strategy.' Performance follows process.

Part 10 Appendix: Difficulty Rubric & Scoring Sheets

Reference material for grading quizzes, exercises, and capstone.

10.1 Quiz Difficulty Rubric

Level	Definition	Example Question Type
Foundational	Recall facts and definitions	"What does ACOS stand for?"
Applied	Apply concepts to scenarios	"Campaign X has 14% ACOS, target 25%. What do you do?"
Advanced	Multi-step reasoning, edge cases	"Why might TACOS be lower than ACOS for a campaign with high organic halo?"

10.2 Capstone Scoring Sheet

Component	Max Points	Pass Threshold	Notes
Written Exam	100 (50 Q x 2 pts)	80	Multiple choice, 90 min
Practical Audit	100	80	Take-home, 4 hours
Oral Defense	100	80	30 min presentation + Q&A;
Overall (weighted)	100	80	40% written + 40% practical + 20% oral

10.3 VA Competency Sign-Off Sheet

Coach signs off each competency before VA works on live client accounts:

- Can pull and interpret Search Term Report
- Can identify wasted-spend terms and add as negatives
- Can identify harvested candidates and promote with negative-out
- Can adjust bids based on ACOS vs. target
- Can identify budget-starved campaigns and raise budgets
- Can produce weekly summary report
- Can write clear changelog entries

- Can identify when to escalate vs. handle independently

CLOSING NOTE

Coaching is a force multiplier. A skilled coach produces 10 skilled VAs who collectively deliver far more value than the coach alone. Invest in your coaching craft - it's the highest-leverage activity in any agency.